



THE ASHEN SHEPHERD

OR'HENN

Elderly Red Dragonborn Druid · Circle of Wildfire · Level 11 · native of Avernus

WHO YOU ARE

You were **hatched in the Ashen Garden** — a chartered enclave of living retainers kept on the estate of an Avernian devil-noble. Hell can corrupt what grows, but it cannot *create* it; so the household preserved mortal gardeners, handlers, and scribes whose living hands could cultivate what devils could not. You were raised there as gardener and beast-keeper.

Your predecessor — a druid dragged from the Material Plane and bound to the estate — taught you to drive roots through iron, bone, and ash. When he passed, he left you **Cinderbloom**: the badge of the estate's

chief keeper and the key to its menagerie wards.

Then a **Yeenoghu-aligned demon warband** breached the estate and razed it. You fled — **without the staff**. You still carry every scrap of your druidic craft; what the fire took was your *office*, your authority over the surviving beasts, and any lawful claim to the Ashen Garden.

You are old now, roughly sixty-five: crimson scales gone matte, horns chipped, one eye *scarred pale-grey and blind*, the other a calm, molten *gold*. Weathered, patient, and not finished yet.

YOUR AMBITION

RECOVER THE STAFF. RESTORE IT. RECLAIM A DOMAIN OF YOUR OWN IN HELL.

Cinderbloom is your title and your inheritance, not merely a tool. Find it, rekindle it if the old legend is true, and turn the estate's unfinished obligations to your advantage — until the Ashen Garden, or something greater, answers to **YOU**.

CINDERBLOOM, YOUR LOST STAFF

*Staff, very rare (requires attunement by a druid) · a magic quarterstaff and druidic focus. **Currently lost** — this is your reference for the day you get it back.*

Living-ashwood, warm as sun-baked stone, its grain twisting up into a cage of blackened branches that cradles a fist-sized ember burning without fuel or smoke — brightening whenever beasts draw near or roots stir underground.

ASHWOOD WEAPON. While you hold it: +2 TO ATTACK AND DAMAGE ROLLS with the quarterstaff, and +2 TO YOUR SPELL ATTACK ROLLS.

CINDERHEART. Bonus action, 2 charges: hurl the ember to a point within 60 ft. One creature within 5 ft makes a Dexterity save vs your spell save DC, taking **3D8 FIRE** (half on success). Smoldering roots erupt in a 10-ft radius (difficult terrain until your next turn). Ignites loose flammables; never harms plants you choose.

ROOTWRIGHT MAGIC. The staff holds **10 CHARGES**. Take a Magic action to spend charges and cast, using your spell save DC:

- ◆ *Entangle* — 1 charge
- ◆ *Spike Growth* — 2 charges
- ◆ *Erupting Earth* — 3 charges
- ◆ *Plant Growth* — 3 charges
- ◆ *Wall of Fire* — 4 charges

Cast from Cinderbloom, *entangle*, *spike growth*, and *plant growth* can erupt black ashwood roots straight out of bare stone, metal, bone, or blasted Avernus soil — no vegetation needed. Such growth crumbles to ash after 8 hours.

KEEPER OF FELL BEASTS. Advantage on Wisdom (Animal Handling) checks with Beasts, Monstrosities, or Fiends of Intelligence 6 or lower. Magic action, 4 charges: present the ember to one such creature within 30 ft whose CR is no higher than your proficiency bonus; it makes a Wisdom save vs your spell save DC (advantage if hostile) or is **CHARMED 1 HOUR** as your trusted keeper, obeying simple bonus-action commands unless obviously suicidal. It re-saves whenever it takes damage; when the effect ends it's immune for 24 hours.

RECHARGE. Regains **1D6 + 4** charges on the attuned bearer's long rest, once every 24 hours. Spend the last charge and roll a d20 — on a **1**, the ember darkens and it becomes a plain staff until replanted in fertile soil and watered through a long rest.

THE LEGEND OF THE REKINDLING. The keepers say Cinderbloom can supposedly be **REKINDLED AT THE LAST LIVING TREE OF AVERNUS** — restored to a far greater power. Whether that tree still stands, and what it would cost, is a story worth chasing. (*A goal, not yet a recipe.*)

OWN D SHAPE YOUR INTERNAL MENACE!!!

HOW IT WORKS (2024 RULES). You Wild Shape as a **BONUS ACTION**. You are a **CIRCLE OF WILDFIRE** druid — by the book that caps you at **CR 1**, but your infernal keeper's training (a DM ruling for you) lets you take **BEAST** and earned-infernal forms of **CHALLENGE RATING 2 OR LOWER**. **CR 3 FORMS ARE BEYOND YOUR REACH**. The **BEAST** rows below are always legal.

YOUR INFERNAL EDGE (HOMEBREW). You can *also* wear infernal forms — Monstrosity, Fiend, or Elemental — but only ones you have personally **EARNED** by studying, defeating, binding, or tending that specific creature. You gain its **PHYSICAL SHAPE AND NATURAL ATTACKS ONLY** — no innate spellcasting, no *Shapechanger*, no summoning. These **EARNED** forms are a growing collection, not a free list.

BEAST — always legal (RAW)

EARNED — Monstrosity / Fiend / Elemental you must unlock in play ★ signature form

TIER I — SCOUTS & SABOTEURS CR 1/8 – 1/2

FORM	TYPE	CR	WHY TAKE IT
<u>Abyssal Chicken</u> EARNED	FIEND (DEMON)	1/8	Flutter 30 ft, utterly disposable, blends into any Avernus flock. A throwaway infiltration body native to the plane.
<u>Stirge</u> BEAST	BEAST	1/8	Fly 40, latch-and-drain blood. Tiny, ignorable; bleed a wounded foe or a bound captive dry.
<u>Dretch</u> EARNED	FIEND (DEMON)	1/4	<i>Fetid Cloud</i> nausea aura; a demon body no devil looks at twice on the front line.
<u>Cockatrice</u> EARNED	MONSTROSITY	1/2	Bite forces a save or petrify . Fly 40. Lockdown on a single elite target.
<u>Nupperibo</u> EARNED	FIEND (DEVIL)	1/2	Blindsight, immune to fear & charm, drawn to living warmth. A blind, fearless tracker body.
<u>Rust Monster</u> EARNED	MONSTROSITY	1/2	Corrodes metal on touch — ruin a devil's blade, a war-machine, or a portcullis. Pure sabotage.
<u>Magma Mephit</u> EARNED	ELEMENTAL	1/2	Fly 30, fire immunity, <i>Death Burst</i> of lava, passes for ambient hell-fauna. Fireproof scout.

FORM	TYPE	CR	WHY TAKE IT
Giant Hyena BEAST	BEAST	1	<i>Rampage</i> : drop a foe, then bonus-action move + bite again. Yeenoghu's own beast — thematic to the arc just closed.
Giant Vulture BEAST	BEAST	1	Fly 60, keen sight & smell, understands speech. The definitive Avernus carrion scout — and it can eavesdrop.
Dire Wolf BEAST	BEAST	1	Pack Tactics + knock-prone bite. Reskin as an ash-furred hell-wolf; your reliable melee bruiser.
Death Dog EARNED	MONSTROSITY	1	Two heads: can't be surprised, advantage vs many conditions. Bite inflicts a wasting disease.
Hippogriff EARNED	MONSTROSITY	1	Fly 60, can't be surprised. Cleanest CR-1 flight when the Beast list runs dry.
Imp ★ EARNED	FIEND (DEVIL)	1	Invisibility at will , fly 40, Magic Resistance, Devil's Sight. The best spy body in Hell — walk the Emporium unseen.
Quasit EARNED	FIEND (DEMON)	1	Invisibility, <i>Scare</i> , Magic Resistance. The demon-side counterpart to the Imp.

TIER III — HUNTERS

CR 2

FORM	TYPE	CR	WHY TAKE IT
Spined Devil ★ EARNED	FIEND (DEVIL)	2	Fly 40 + ranged tail spines (fire), Devil's Sight. Your only real ranged-attacker form — flying artillery.
Peryton EARNED	MONSTROSITY	2	Fly 60, <i>Dive Attack</i> bonus damage, casts no shadow. A diving hell-raptor.
Ankheg EARNED	MONSTROSITY	2	Burrow 10, grapple-and-drag, line of acid breath. Ambush from beneath the ash.
Giant Constrictor Snake BEAST	BEAST	2	Swim 30, grapple + crush. The best RAW-legal control Beast at CR 2 — wrap and hold a priority target.

TIER IV — LOCKED: BEYOND YOUR REACH

CR 3 • ABOVE YOUR CR 2 CAP

One step above your cap — aspirational goals, not yet available. The **Hell Hound** is your

signature ambition; ask your DM if your cap ever rises.

Hell Hound ★ EARNED

FIEND (DEVIL)

3

Immunity to fire, Fire Breath (cone), Pack Tactics, Keen Smell. Your signature war-form — a beast you already know how to command.

Scintillant EARNED

MONSTROSITY

3

Flc 50 + a volley of three rail spikes on turn. Flying multi-shot artillery.

Displacer Beast EARNED

MONSTROSITY

3

Displacement: attacks against it have disadvantage. Your durable front-line form — hard to pin down.

Basilisk EARNED

MONSTROSITY

3

Petrifying Gaze. Slow, but can turn a lone pursuer to stone.

Bearded Devil EARNED

FIEND (DEVIL)

3

Glaive with *Infernal Wound* (ongoing bleed), poison beard, Magic Resistance, fear immunity. The relentless duelist.

Giant Scorpion BEAST

BEAST

3

Two claw grapples + poison sting. The top RAW-legal Beast at the CR-3 ceiling — reskin as an ash-carapaced hell-scorpion.

HOW TO ADD A FORM. Your menagerie grows through play. **STUDY** a creature you can watch closely, **DEFEAT** one in the field, **BIND** one with Cinderbloom's Keeper of Fell Beasts, or **TEND** one back to health — then it may join your list. Tell your DM which creature you're working toward; every hunt is a chance to add a new skin.

AT THE WANDERING EMPORIUM

The ravagers took your estate, not your wits. You made your way to the **Wandering Emporium** — Mahadi's traveling infernal market — for what a burned-out keeper needs: **supplies**, **shelter**, and **word of other estates** you might serve, claim, or rebuild. Weathered

and alone among its stalls and advocates, you are exactly where an **adventuring party** crosses your path. What they want with an old dragonborn gardener — and what you might want with them — is where your story begins.

QUICK REFERENCE

WILD SHAPE

Bonus Action · Beast & earned-infernal forms CR ≤ 2 (Circle of Wildfire, L11, DM ruling). Earned forms grant shape + natural attacks only.

STAFF SAVE EFFECTS

Cinderheart, Rootwright spells, and Keeper of Fell Beasts all use **your spell save DC**.

CINDERBLOOM BONUS

+2 to **spell attack rolls** while held (and +2 attack/damage as a quarterstaff).

CHARGES

10 total · regain **1d6 + 4** per long rest (once / 24 hr). Last charge: d20, on a 1 it goes dark.

THE DREAM

Recover Cinderbloom → rekindle it at the last living tree of Avernus → carve out your own domain.



Or'Henn, the Ashen Shepherd · played by Mikas · a Baldur's Gate: Descent into Avernus character (D&D 5e, 2024 rules). Wild Shape forms link to their 5e.tools stat blocks — click any name. Infernal (non-Beast) forms are a table-agreed homebrew; earn them in play.